



Tarot Mysticism

Core Card Meanings

Joe Monteleone
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This book is intended for educational and spiritual exploration purposes only. It is not a substitute for medical, psychological, legal, or financial advice.

All divinatory interpretations and tarot practices described in this book are provided for personal reflection and entertainment purposes only. The reader is solely responsible for their own decisions and actions. The author assumes no liability for any outcomes resulting from the use of this material.

The System

The tarot stands at a complex crossroads of Hermetic philosophy, Qabalah, numerology, and symbolic systems drawn from multiple spiritual traditions. The nineteenth and twentieth centuries only accelerated tarot's role within esoteric philosophy. As a result, there are many valid ways to interpret the seventy-eight tarot cards. New students are often overwhelmed by the volume of information and the contradictory meanings attached to each card, stumbling over keywords and uncertain how to combine cards for accurate interpretation.

Despite the diversity of interpretations, a coherent set of core meanings naturally emerges from the confluence of the Western Mystery Tradition, and more broadly, the Perennial Philosophy as a whole. Beneath the variation, a unified structure exists. This book introduces the foundational elements of that structure, helping you isolate the subtler core meanings from which many modern-day interpretations arise.

Internalizing these core meanings allows the cards to reveal their underlying architecture. From that architecture, countless messages unfold. Instead of overthinking keywords and forgetting what you hoped to memorize, the structure you internalize is used as a narrowing funnel for your broader intuition, leading to more powerful and helpful divination.

After learning the system, record your observations in this workbook and test how its structural principles manifest within your own divination practice.

The Perennial Philosophy

Mysticism is the word I use to describe anything that helps one unite with reality itself. The union of the individual, separate self with the totality of reality is the end of suffering. But even in these statements, there is a lie. At the highest level, it is realized that there was never a separate entity in the first place. At Tarot Mysticism Academy, I teach my students how to use tarot as a psycho-spiritual technology to support such realizations.

Tarot, like spiritual development, can be understood through three levels. These levels are used pedagogically to provide context for different, and often contradictory, forms of *sadhana*. In some contexts, they may be described as general planes of existence. Although presented as three planes, they are ultimately manifestations of one reality. For teaching purposes, however, I describe them as three expressions of a fourth, more fundamental reality that cannot be divided.

The first level is the “mechanical plane.” It is the world as it appears mundanely. Reality is viewed through a Newtonian lens, where events unfold through cause and effect. Within this perspective, agency appears limited and experience seems determined by external forces.

The second level is the “subtle plane.” Reality is experienced as a complex flow of subtle experiences. Some call this the energy body. Some call it the nervous system. Some call it the astral plane. In this view of reality, the individual entity appears to create its own experience. In one’s personal development, this is the full development of the ego. This phase involves one consciously understanding their deeper desires and achieving the internal harmony required to realize them.

The “mystical plane” is the final plane that can be discussed. It is where one confronts the illusion of separation. This is the last point that can be meaningfully approached through words, before silence itself. Here, the *mahavakyas* and other great sayings attempt to point directly to one’s true nature. In the context of personal development, this stage is the final surrender of the ego that was fully developed but never really existed.

The fourth plane cannot be spoken of. It is non-dual and all language is inherently dual. These planes provide a necessary contextual framework for understanding how tarot functions at different levels of perception.

In practice, the tarot can only function on the first two levels, but can begin to suggest the third level to support the realization of the fourth. The following workbook translates these various levels of meaning into an introductory practical system of core divinatory meanings.

Non-Duality

Paradigm: What world?

"I am."

Mystical Plane

First Duality



Tarot Mysticism Method: Used to collapse the distance between all experience, connecting "everything" to "everything", and suggesting "nothing".

Causal Plane

Inner Duality



Paradigm: I am the world.

"I am X and I am Y"

Subtle Plane



Mystical Philosophy: Used to navigate the inner world and reflect on the transpersonal human experience.

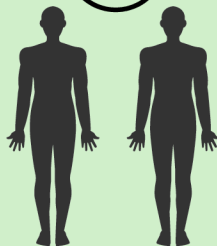
Outer Duality



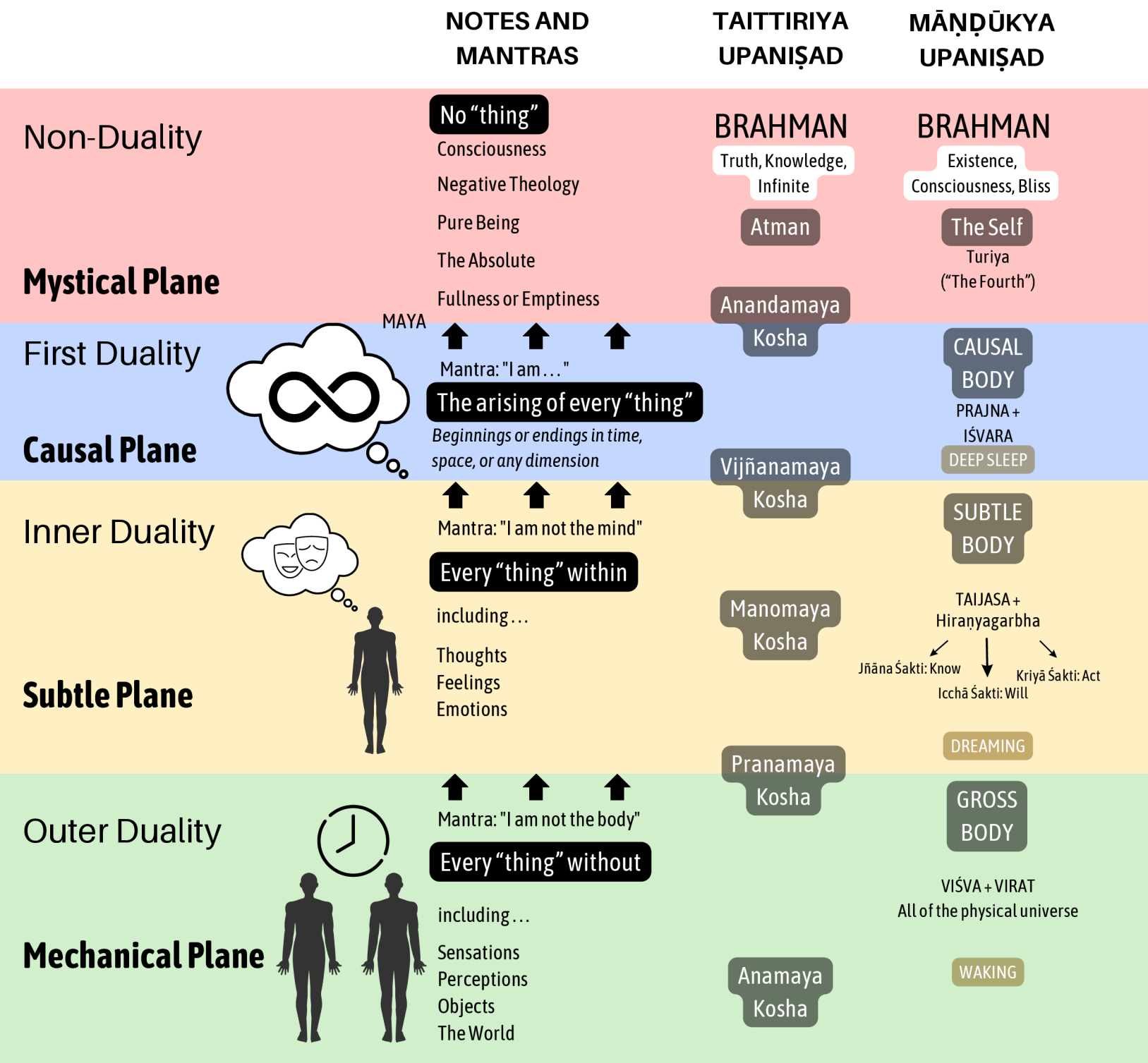
Paradigm: I am in the world.

"X and Y happens to me."

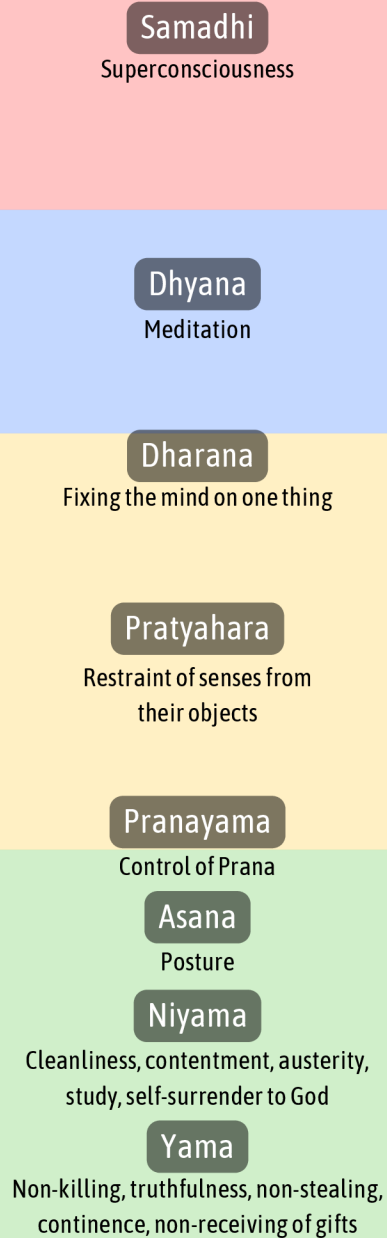
Mechanical Plane



Tarot divination: Used to navigate the outer world and reflect on the personal self.



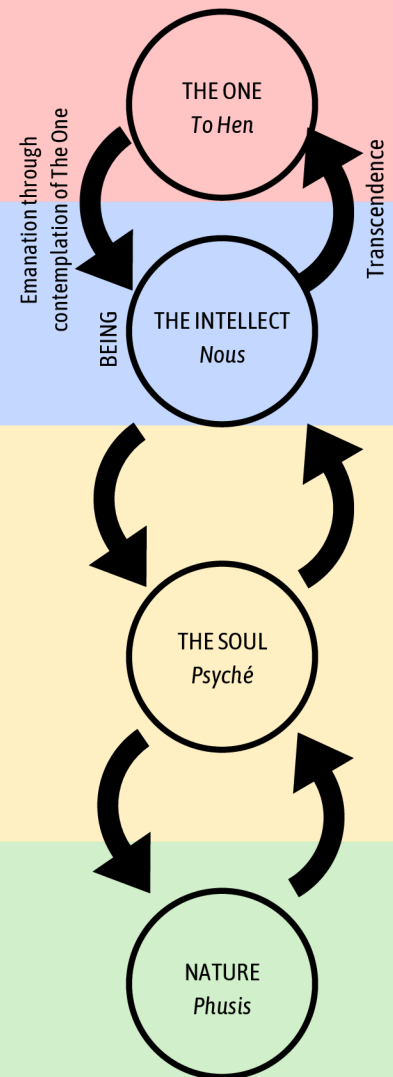
YOGA



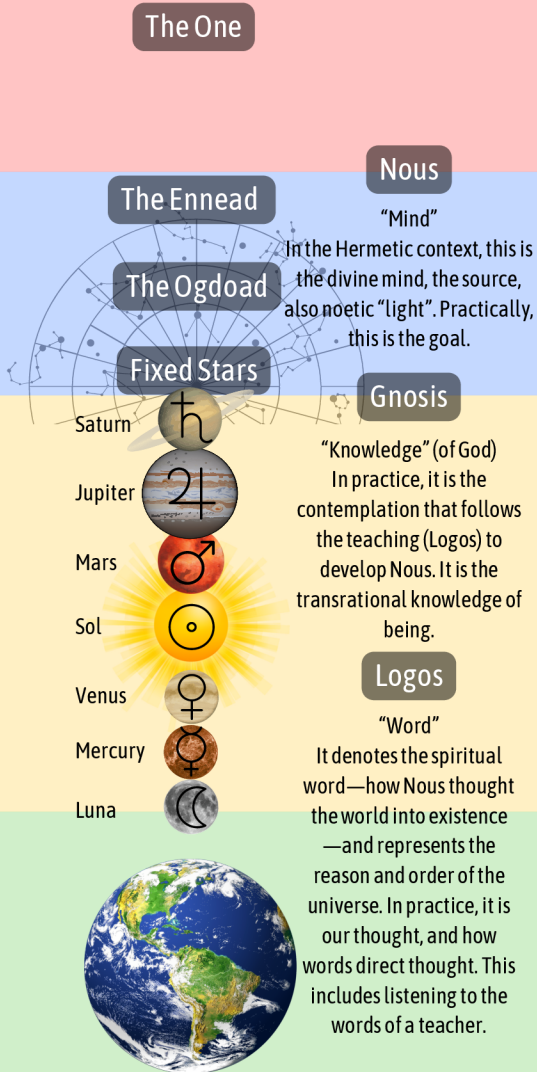
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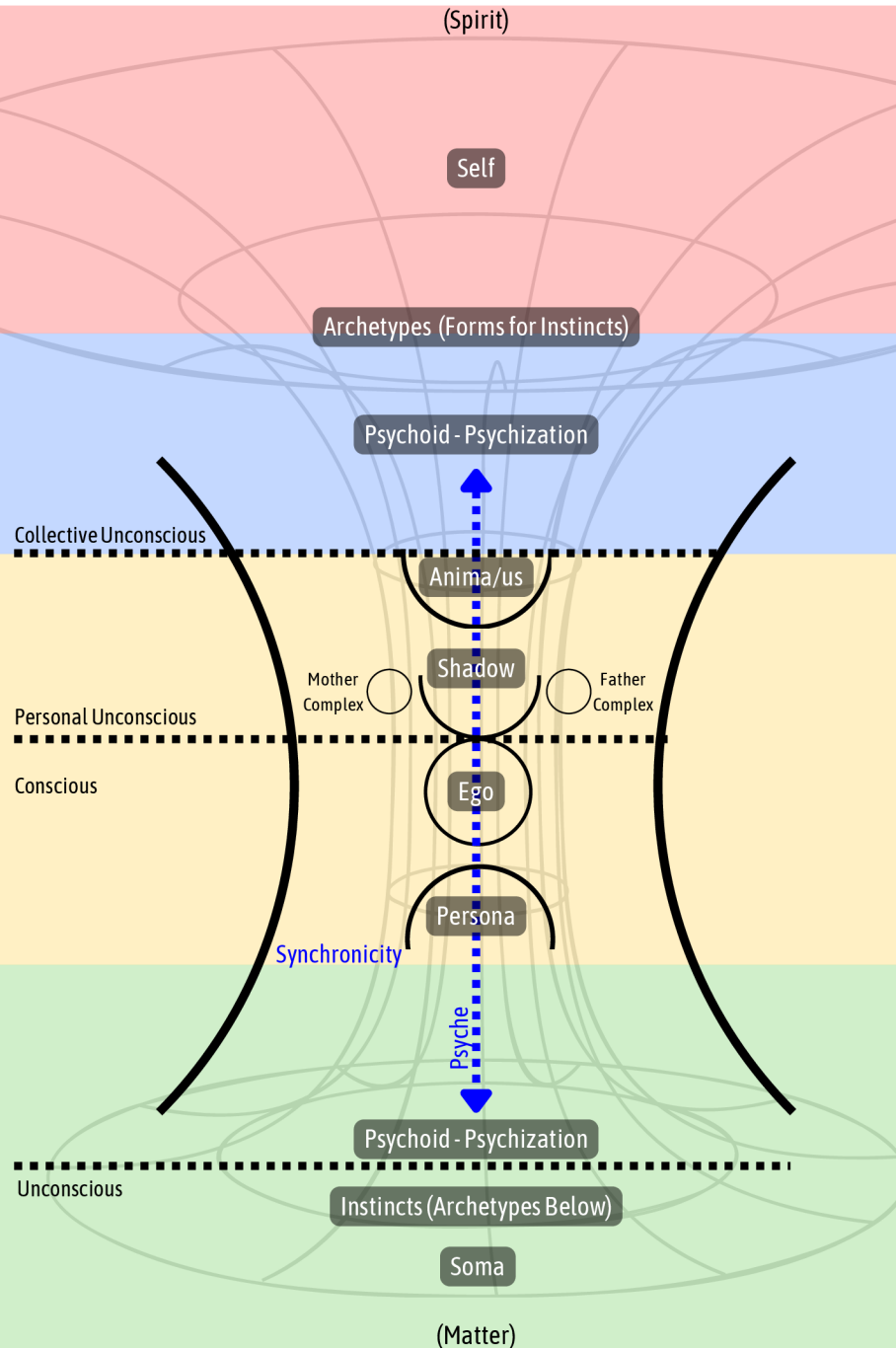
PLOTINUS



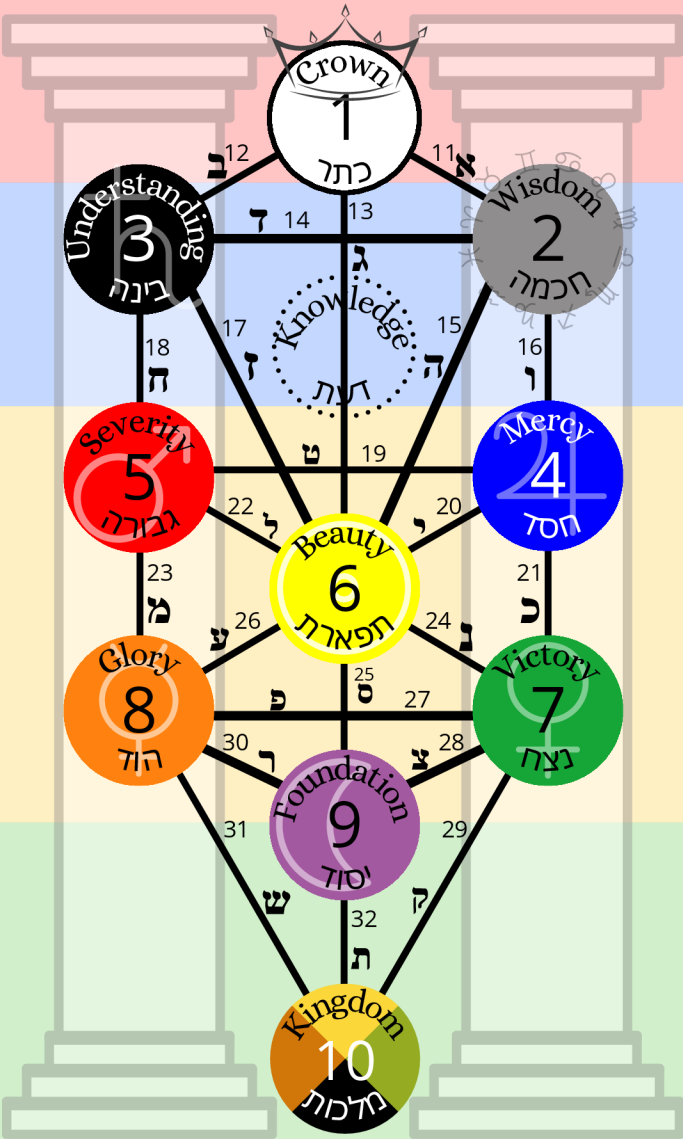
HERMETICISM AND ASTROLOGY



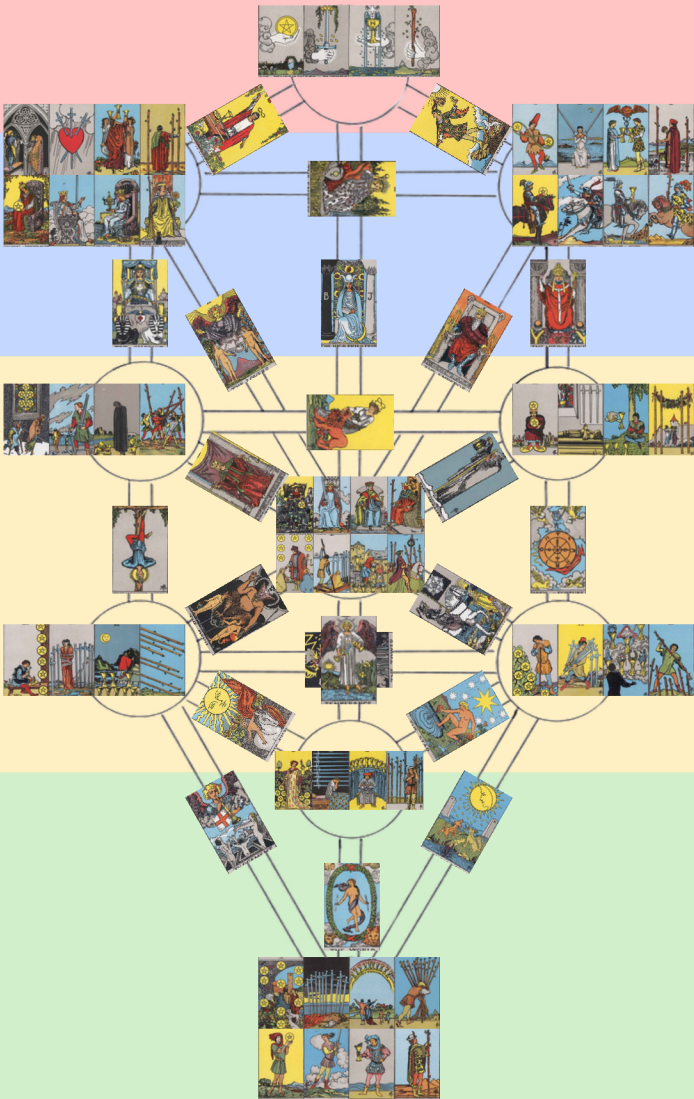
CARL JUNG



QABALISTIC TREE OF LIFE



TAROT



Learning the Tarot Mysticism System

To fully understand the intricacies of these systems takes years of dedicated study. This workbook introduces the Tarot Mysticism system by revealing the core meanings from which many modern interpretations arise. These foundational meanings expand your interpretive range and lead to more powerful, accurate readings.

To support your continued study, I've created a free course that guides you through this workbook step by step, along with additional resources, available at the link below:

www.tarotmysticismacademy.com/free-classes

The Structure of the Tarot

The tarot is divided into the major arcana and the minor arcana. The major arcana include twenty-two trump cards with no suits. The minor arcana have four suits: wands, cups, swords, and pentacles (or disks or coins). They are further divided into “small cards,” which are numbered ace through ten, and “court cards,” which have four offices: page, knight, queen, and king.

When you draw a card, you will either draw a major arcana card, a small card, or a court card.

We will begin with the minor arcana. When drawing a minor arcana card, first notice the number or office. The ten numbers and four offices have specific meanings. Next, notice the suit. The four suits have specific meanings. When you combine the meaning of the number or office with the meaning of the suit, you get the meaning of the card. The following pages detail this process.

Learning the ten numbers and the four suits gives you the meaning of over half the tarot deck. Adding the meanings of the four offices means you know the entire minor arcana.

The major arcana are more nuanced. They can be organized into three septenaries (three rows of seven), which also divide them into three ternaries (seven columns of three). By learning the meanings of the three septenaries and seven ternaries, you understand the structure of the majors. You can learn these first or, if easier, learn the major arcana cards individually.

Following this system provides a core meaning. Unlike keywords, core meanings are more powerful and subtle. They do not automatically give you a way to interpret the card. Rather, they give you a deeper conceptual understanding of the card’s essence. This essence then manifests as more concrete interpretations with a wider scope of meaning.

So, how do you use these core meanings for practical divination?

You combine the core meanings with your intuition and the context of the reading, including the question and spread. This combination results in both an intuitively and intellectually informed tarot practice.

Intuition

Divination

**Spread Context and
Methodology**

Core Meanings ➡

40 Small Cards

Ace:
An opportunity for ...

Two:
A focused force of ...

Three:
Receiving or understanding ...

Four:
Comfort in ...

Five:
Discomfort in ...

Six:
Victory in ...

Seven:
Strained, individual effort in ...

Eight:
A surrender to ...

Nine:
The fulfillment through ...

Ten:
An excess of ...

4 Suits

Wands:
drive, creativity, ambition,
personal will

Cups:
connection, love,
emotional life, intuition

Swords:
thought, conflict,
ego, social or virtual reality

Pentacles:
resources, work, health,
material life

16 Court Cards

King:
An intellectual or leading
influence on ...

Queen:
A receptive, guiding, intuitive
influence on ...

Knight:
Someone actively engaging ...

Page:
Someone learning about ...

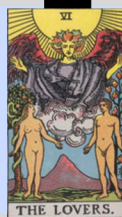
Pick a card.



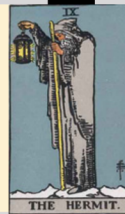
22 Major Arcana Cards:

Conation Negation Genesis Ordering Disclosure Superimposition/
Desuperimposition Integration

Mystical
Plane



Subtle
Plane



Mechanical
Plane



Wands

Core Meaning

Manifestations



Ace of Wands

An opportunity for drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Two of Wands

A focused force of drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Three of Wands

Receiving or understanding drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Four of Wands

Comfort in drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Five of Wands

Discomfort in drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Six of Wands

Victory in drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Seven of Wands

Strained, individual effort in drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Eight of Wands

A surrender to drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Nine of Wands

The fulfillment achieved through drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Ten of Wands

An excess of drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Page of Wands

Someone learning about drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Knight of Wands

Someone actively engaging drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Queen of Wands

A receptive, guiding, intuitive influence on drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

King of Wands

An intellectual or leading influence on drive, creativity, ambition, personal will

Cups

Core Meaning

Manifestations



Ace of Cups

An opportunity for connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Two of Cups

A focused force of connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Three of Cups

Receiving or understanding connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Four of Cups

Comfort in connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Five of Cups

Discomfort in connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Six of Cups

Victory in connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Seven of Cups

Strained, individual effort in connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Eight of Cups

A surrender to connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Nine of Cups

The fulfillment achieved through connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Ten of Cups

An excess of connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Page of Cups

Someone learning about connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Knight of Cups

Someone actively engaging connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Queen of Cups

A receptive, guiding, intuitive influence on connection, love, emotional life, intuition

King of Cups

An intellectual or leading influence on connection, love, emotional life, intuition

Swords

Core Meaning

Manifestations



Ace of Swords

An opportunity for thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Two of Swords

A focused force of thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Three of Swords

Receiving or understanding thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Four of Swords

Comfort in thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Five of Swords

Discomfort in thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Six of Swords

Victory in thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Seven of Swords

Strained, individual effort in thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Eight of Swords

A surrender to thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Nine of Swords

The fulfillment achieved through thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Ten of Swords

An excess of thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Page of Swords

Someone learning about thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Knight of Swords

Someone actively engaging thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Queen of Swords

A receptive, guiding, intuitive influence on thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

King of Swords

An intellectual or leading influence on thought, conflict, ego, social or virtual reality

Pentacles

Core Meaning

Manifestations



Ace of Pentacles

An opportunity for resources, work, health, material life

Two of Pentacles

A focused force of resources, work, health, material life

Three of Pentacles

Receiving or understanding resources, work, health, material life

Four of Pentacles

Comfort in resources, work, health, material life

Five of Pentacles

Discomfort in resources, work, health, material life

Six of Pentacles

Victory in resources, work, health, material life

Seven of Pentacles

Strained, individual effort in resources, work, health, material life

Eight of Pentacles

A surrender to resources, work, health, material life

Nine of Pentacles

The fulfillment achieved through resources, work, health, material life

Ten of Pentacles

An excess of resources, work, health, material life

Page of Pentacles

Someone learning about resources, work, health, material life

Knight of Pentacles

Someone actively engaging resources, work, health, material life

Queen of Pentacles

A receptive, guiding, intuitive influence on resources, work, health, material life

King of Pentacles

An intellectual or leading influence on resources, work, health, material life

First Septenary

Core Meaning

Manifestations



I The Magician

Ternary: Conation
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: The Logos, play, attention



II The Priestess

Ternary: Negation
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: Secrets, spiritual influence, silence, null



III The Empress

Ternary: Genesis
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: Beauty, motherhood, love, nurture, growth, fertility



IV The Emperor

Ternary: Ordering
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: Self, individuation, law, rule, sovereignty



V The Hierophant

Ternary: Disclosure
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: Explanation, mysteries, spiritual technology



VI The Lovers

Ternary: De/Superimposition
Septenary: Mystical

Essence: Relationship, difference, choice, multiplicity



VII The Chariot

Ternary: Integration
Septenary: Mystical plane

Essence: Integration, adeptship, control, vehicle of higher forces

Second Septenary

Core Meaning

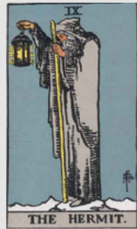
Manifestations



VIII Strength

Ternary: Conation
Septenary: Subtle

Essence: Creativity, desire,
articulation, inner duality



IX The Hermit

Ternary: Negation
Septenary: Subtle

Essence: Isolation, guidance,
wisdom



X The Wheel of Fortune

Ternary: Genesis
Septenary: Subtle

Essence: Cycles, cosmic law,
manifestation, chance



XI Justice

Ternary: Ordering
Septenary: Subtle

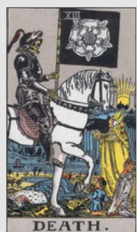
Essence: Balance, karma,
causality, repercussion



XII The Hanged Man

Ternary: Disclosure
Septenary: Subtle

Essence: Surrender, uniqueness,
mortality, transcendence



XIII Death

Ternary: De/Superimposition
Septenary: Subtle

Essence: Transformation, perceived
loss, movement



XIV Temperance

Ternary: Integration
Septenary: Subtle plane

Essence: Combination, moderation,
dynamism

Third Septenary

Core Meaning

Manifestations



XV The Devil

Ternary: Conation
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Generation, attachment, matter, drives



XVI The Tower

Ternary: Negation
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Catastrophe, chaos, illumination



XVII The Star

Ternary: Genesis
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Hope, healing, possibility



XVIII The Moon

Ternary: Ordering
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Animal instinct, unconsciousness, illusion



XIX The Sun

Ternary: Disclosure
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Liberty, vitality, success, revelation, spontaneity



XX Judgement

Ternary: De/Superimposition
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Singularity, the call, awakening



XXI The World

Ternary: Integration
Septenary: Mechanical

Essence: Completion, every "thing"

0 The Fool



Essence: No "thing"

Every card up to this point has represented something. A thing exists because it is distinguishable. It has a beginning or an ending in time, space, or any dimension. It is made, done, differentiated, or changeable. It is here or there, coming or going.

Unlike something, The Fool is nothing.

Do not mistake nothing for the absence of something. Simply reverse it.

Nothing is that which has no beginning and no end in time, space, or any dimension. It is not made, done, differentiated, or changeable. It is neither here nor there, neither coming nor going.

Its nature is ineffable, yet it is irrefutable.

It is that in which all things exist.

It is.

Self-evident.

Notes

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Notes

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About the Author

Joe Monteleone, described by the Huffington Post as a "one-man-band of magical-thinking-made reality," is a Tarot master teacher, coach, YouTuber, modern mystic, and best-selling author of *Tarot Mysticism: The Psycho-Spiritual Technology of the Thoth Tarot*. Joe has read, performed, and taught tarot and mystical philosophy across both physical and virtual stages, including The Readers Studio, World Divination Association, Esoteracle Magazine, and the New York Pagan Pride Festival. He is the founder of the Tarot Mysticism Academy, where he guides hundreds of mystical misfits around the globe in exploring the edges of reality through tarot's perennial philosophy. For more information, visit:

www.tarotmysticismacademy.com



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